

Don't Budge!

The Reputational Cost of Political Compromises

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Abstract

How do citizens evaluate political parties' willingness to compromise during coalition negotiations in representative democracies? While previous research has shown that citizens support the principle of political compromise, it remains unclear how parties' compromise acceptance during coalition negotiations affects the voters' trust. We argue that parties incur substantial reputational costs when they are willing to compromise during coalition negotiations. Using a pre-registered survey experiment in Germany fielded immediately after the 2021 parliamentary elections ($N=7,562$), we find that voters place more trust in their parties when they remain steadfast during negotiations. Highly principled individuals and those with low social trust are particularly likely to reject compromising parties. Additionally, we probe the generalizability of our experimental findings with a cross-country observational study, going beyond the case of Germany. Given the centrality of compromise in representative democracy, these findings suggest that political distrust may be a systemic component of representative democracy.

Keywords: Political compromise; coalition negotiations; political trust; representative democracy; survey experiment

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Introduction

Compromise is a defining characteristic of representative democracy. It is a prerequisite for government formation and lawmaking in all democracies, and particularly so in multiparty systems with coalition governments (Lijphart 1999; Gutmann and Thompson 2014). Citizens' acceptance of compromises is therefore pivotal for democracy's perceived legitimacy. The good news is that most citizens seem to support the *principle* of political compromise. The abstract principle of compromise finds broad public support among citizens (hjerimitslev2022; Harbridge et al. 2014; Wolak 2020). In European countries, 60 percent or more of the voters support the democratic principle of compromise (van der Velden 2023). Abstract support notwithstanding, groundbreaking observational work has shown that compromises in government coalitions diminish a party's programmatic profile, which in turn can negatively affect their support (Fortunato and Stevenson 2013; Harbridge et al. 2014; Fortunato and Adams 2015; Fortunato 2019a; Fernandez-Vazquez 2020).

The key theoretical and empirical question is therefore how citizens evaluate a party's willingness to compromise during coalition negotiations against the counterfactual of the party remaining steadfast, which could jeopardize government participation. We posit that the fact that there is widespread support for the *idea* of compromise does not mean that citizens will refrain from punishing political parties for their willingness to compromise in political negotiations. While it is easy to embrace the principle of compromise when little is at stake, we argue that citizens' commitment to political compromise is truly put to the test when a party has to decide whether to accept or reject a compromise on a specific, salient issue during coalition negotiations.

Our key contribution is answering the above described question by examining the reputational costs of a party's decision when it makes the trade-off between their representative function and the responsible function, (e.g., see Harbridge et al. 2014, p. 350, who highlight the necessity of such research). In other words, parties must balance their policy-seeking goals with their office-seeking goals (Müller and

Strøm 1999). We assert that these functions of parties pose competing demands on the party leadership (Mair 2009; Bardi et al. 2014). When evaluating parties' performance during coalition negotiations, citizens must adjudicate between the conflicting virtues of policy representation and governing responsibility in office.

In real life, political parties are often confronted with the decision to either compromise on a key issue or step out of the coalition negotiations, thereby trading off their representative function and their responsive function. For instance, after the 2017 Dutch parliamentary elections, the GreenLeft party (*GroenLinks*) was caught between this rock and a hard place. After the party decided to stick to their positions on migration policy, the coalition negotiations faltered, precluding any chance for the party to steer government policy in office (de Vries 2017). While some voters appreciated the GreenLeft's principled position, others criticized the party for not taking government responsibility.¹ Similarly, the breakdown of coalition talks in Germany in 2017 involving Merkel's CDU, the Greens (*die Grünen*), and the German FDP has been ascribed to the FDP's reluctance to concede on pivotal matters (Beitzer 2017), for which it received considerable public criticism (Hemicker 2017). In our study, we perform a stylized test of this trade-off between compromising on a single issue (or not) at the cost of coalition talks breaking down (vs. the talks continuing).

We conduct a [preregistered survey experiment](#) to 7,562 respondents in Germany immediately after the 2021 *Bundestag* elections.² Our study presents respondents with a scenario in which we experimentally manipulate the negotiation strategy (i.e., remaining steadfast vs. accepting a compromise) of respondents preferred party (i.e., their 'in-party') as well as the success of negotiation talks (i.e., negotiations continue vs. negotiations stall). This approach enables us to examine the effect of compromise acceptance whilst keeping the negotiation success constant as well as whether success during the negotiations (i.e., stalling or continuing talks) affects citizens' evaluations of compromise (see also Fortunato 2021, Ch. 4).

¹For a full discussion, see the report by the Scientific Desk of the GreenLeft (Wetenschappelijk Bureau GroenLinks 2021, p. 6).

²All analytical material can be found on our [Online Compendium](#)

We examine the party’s reputational costs in three ways. First, to capture party reputation we preregistered the effect of compromise on people’s trust of the party – in line with the existing literature (e.g., see Bøggild 2020). Additionally, we explore different dimensions of a party’s reputation by studying the effects of compromise on the party’s perceived credibility and its perceived representational performance. For the latter two, we have not preregistered the effects and treat them as exploratory dependent variables.³ We conduct our tests for two salient issues, namely an economic issue (increase of the top tax rate) and a cultural issue (speed limit on the German *Autobahn*). To ensure experimental realism and to increase engagement with the experimental stimulus, we present the scenarios as simulated party communication in the form of an Instagram message. As we show in Section C of the [Online Appendix](#) (OA), such a visual presentation increases exposure to the stimulus material compared to a plain textual prompt.

We find that citizens are more likely to find their party trustworthy and credible when it remains steadfast during coalition negotiations than when it accepts a compromise. This finding holds across most parties and across both policy issues. This negative effect of party compromise is not attenuated by success during the negotiation process, suggesting that respondents value policy representation over attaining office and governing responsibility. Moreover, we test the generalizability of our experimental findings by probing whether the relationship between compromise acceptance and political trust holds cross-nationally in 9 European democracies using observational data of the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) (Lenzner et al. 2016). On the basis of CSES data, we find that anti-compromise attitudes are significantly correlated with low trust in politicians and low levels of satisfaction with democracy in most West European countries. This provides suggestive evidence that our experimental findings from Germany may well apply across different political contexts.

Our second contribution to the literature on political compromise is that we

³In the paper, we display the effect for credibility, and in the Online Appendix, the effects for representation are shown.

empirically test the individual-level mechanisms of compromise acceptance, as theorized by Gutmann and Thompson (2014). According to the authors, an *uncompromising mindset* is facilitated by two individual-level characteristics: (a) *principled tenacity*; and (b) *mutual mistrust*. Principled tenacity refers to an attitude in which one does not forsake their principles at all costs, even when it might be in their interests to do so (see Wolak, 2020, Ch. 3; Ryan, 2017; Arceneaux, 2019). Mutual mistrust towards opponents is characterized by the belief that one’s opponents are mainly motivated by a desire to defeat them, rather than finding common ground to mutual benefit (see also Zmerli and Newton 2008). In line with Gutmann and Thompson (2014)’s theoretical propositions, we find that highly principled respondents and respondents with low levels of social trust are more likely to evaluate a compromising party less positively than a steadfast party.

The findings of our study are sobering. Despite the apparent public support for the principle of political compromise, respondents in our study find their preferred party (‘in-party’) less trustworthy and less credible when it accepts a compromise, as opposed to an uncompromising stance. In addition, respondents believe a party does a worse job in representing its voters when it is willing to compromise. Policy representation, not responsibility in government negotiations, seems to be valued more by citizens. Given the centrality of political compromise in virtually all representative democracies, these findings do not bode well for the perceived legitimacy of representative democracy. If distrust follows from party compromise, low political trust could be a *systemic*, integral component of representative democracy – particularly in multiparty democracies characterized by coalition governments and consensus building.

The Desirability of Political Compromise

Political theorists both emphasize the importance of compromise in representative democracy (e.g., see Gutmann and Thompson 2014; Margalit 2009; Mansbridge and Martin 2013) as well as the difficulties they pose to representative democratic

systems (White and Ypi 2016). Virtually all political decision-making is subject to political compromise. Given that representative democracy presupposes the legitimacy of competing political claims for the common good (Muirhead 2006; Herman 2017), compromise with one’s adversaries signals the recognition that one’s own views remain ‘partial and temporary’ (Rosenblum, 2010, p. 364; see also White and Ypi, 2016, p. 152). Political compromise, thus, can be seen as a democratically desirable aggregation of competing views (Kelsen, 2013; White and Ypi, 2016, p. 150-152). At same time, compromises also have diluting effects: When a party compromises on its principles, it downplays its ‘ideational commitments’, which can cause confusion among its electorate. White and Ypi (2016, p. 163) make the normative argument that given the principled nature of partisan commitments, compromise in itself should not be intrinsically valued. Compromises are inherently paradoxical: Whereas accepting a compromise constitutes a violation of one’s principles, rejecting compromise at all costs inhibits the realization of one’s political aspirations (White and Ypi 2016; Margalit 2009).

The paradox of compromise (White and Ypi 2016) becomes a “double-edged sword” for political parties: During coalition negotiations, parties must navigate the tension between policy representation (i.e., maintaining the ideological and ideational association with their voters) and responsibility (i.e., the opportunity to realize their policy goals in office) (Mair 2009; Gutmann and Thompson 2014, pp. 16-24). Put another way, parties must strike a balance between their policy-seeking goals and their office-seeking goals (Müller and Strøm 1999; Gross et al. 2024).

These functions often pose contradictory demands on party leadership (Mair 2009; Bardi et al. 2014; Gross et al. 2024). On the one hand, many citizens seem to support compromise (greenpedersen2023; Wolak 2020) as well as political candidates embracing the practice of political compromise (Wolak 2020; Hjermit-slev 2025; GREEN-PEDERSEN and Hjermit-slev 2024). What is more, citizens’ commitment to the *principle* of compromise seems to be genuine and not a consequence of social desirability bias, as the experimental studies by Green-Pedersen and Hjermit-slev show.

On the other hand, it is likely that such explicit support differs from citizens' implicit attitudes towards compromise. Harbridge et al. (2014) argue that when studies directly measure whether respondents prefer compromising politicians over unflinching ones, they likely cue the positive valence of political compromise, driving support for compromise. With experimental designs, however, respondents are not aware of which attitudes are measured, thereby limiting the effects of positive valence cues (Kam 2007). What is more, support for political compromise is more likely when there are no clear costs or trade-offs at play. If we are to get a better understanding of how political compromise affects trust in political parties, the issue is not merely whether citizens support the *idea of compromise* but whether they would support political compromise in *practice*.

Do citizens prioritize the virtue of holding unflinching policy commitments or, instead, accept concessions to facilitate government participation? Based on one strand of the literature, one could expect that citizens in multiparty democracies prefer 'responsible' parties that are prepared to make policy concessions in order to successfully conclude coalition negotiations and attain office, since most policies are the result of compromises (Martin and Vanberg 2014). Citizens tend to be more satisfied with democracy when their preferred party is in government (Anderson et al. 2005; Singh et al. 2012), which could make them more sympathetic to political compromise (e.g., see Wolak 2020). After all, governing parties are more likely to see their preferred policies enacted in legislation. Voters are also found to value coalition participation as such (Bowler et al. 2010), and take the composition of future coalitions into account when voting to express which coalition they prefer (Bargsted and Kedar 2009; Duch et al. 2010).

Despite these possible positive views on compromise, we argue that citizens prefer their political parties to be firm in their policy commitments during political negotiations. After all, only a clear and distinct ideological and programmatic identity can set a party apart from its competitors (Andreottola 2021; White 2021). In addition, while research on the effects of 'winning' and 'losing' in elections has found clear effects of winning on regime support (van der Meer and Steenvoorden

2018), it is far from clear that compromise during negotiations is considered a ‘win’. Rather, Harbridge et al. (2014, p. 328-9) suggest that compromises “may produce outputs that are more akin to losses than wins for a particular party, especially if the alternative is standing firm”. Having a “winners” mindset, moreover, does not foster a compromising mindset (e.g., see De Dreu et al. 2000). Furthermore, given that voters are generally risk-averse (Bernhardt and Ingerman 1985), they should dislike the uncertainty that is associated with parties departing from their previously stated policy commitments (see Tomz and Van Houweling 2013, for evidence to that effect). What is more, previous research has shown that repositioning can have adverse effects on electoral success (Tavits 2007; Doherty et al. 2016; Meijers 2025; Tomz and Van Houweling 2016; Sorek et al. 2018). Lupu (2013, 2014) shows that inconsistent party positions and alliances with former rivals can result in ‘brand dilution’, i.e., the blurring of a party’s programmatic profile which can ultimately contribute to its demise.

Crucially, research has shown that voters take notice when parties obfuscate their ‘pure’ policy commitments by brokering compromises with coalition partners. Recent studies have shown that parties’ coalition participation affects the clarity of their policy positions from the perspective of voters. For instance, citizens perceive coalition partners to be ideologically more proximate (Fortunato and Stevenson 2013; Falcó-Gimeno and Fernandez-Vazquez 2020), and voters update their perceptions of party positions after coalition negotiations (Fortunato 2019b; Plescia 2022). Citizens particularly update their perceptions of the positions of smaller coalition parties to reflect the policy profile of the prime minister’s party (Fortunato and Adams 2015; Adams et al. 2016). Only when coalition parties adopt extreme positions during subsequent elections can they offset such voter discounting (Bawn and Somer-Topcu 2012; Fernandez-Vazquez 2020). This suggests that citizens are aware of coalition compromises, and update their party perceptions accordingly. And while there is evidence that ‘broad appeal’ strategies can bring parties electoral success (Somer-Topcu 2015), obfuscating specific policy positions is costly (Bartels 1986), especially when this pertains to issue that are ‘on-brand’

(Gunderson 2024).

What is more, there is evidence that citizens perceive partisan compromise as a negatively valenced outcome. While compromises are ideally to the mutual benefit of both parties, Harbridge et al. (2011; 2014) find US voters do not prefer bipartisan compromises over partisan wins. In addition, Fortunato (2019; 2021) finds that citizens tend to punish parties that have been willing to compromise on policy questions at the polls.

Finally, Gross et al. (2024) find that when in-partisans must adjudicate between policy congruence or political office (i.e., a ministerial position), they tend to prioritize policy congruence over office-seeking considerations.

Hypotheses: The Reputational Costs of Compromise

We argue that the research design of previous studies inhibits a conclusive answer to the question of how citizens in multiparty democracies act when cross-pressured between two representational ideals. In particular, extant studies have not been able to analytically separate citizens' evaluations of partisan compromise from evaluations of the (non-)success of the negotiations in multiparty democracies (e.g., Bawn and Somer-Topcu 2012; Fortunato and Stevenson 2013; Fortunato and Adams 2015). Yet the effect of the counterfactual of not participating in the coalition is not clear. A survey experiment conducted by Fortunato (2021, Ch. 4) has been a very important first step in establishing citizens' implicit disdain for specific compromises. Prompting respondents with scenarios of two fictitious parties engaged in coalition negotiations, Fortunato shows that respondents tend to favour a stalemate over any form of compromise. Yet in this study, the presence of a party compromise and the success of the negotiation are also conflated. What is more, Plescia et al. (2022) find in a survey fielded immediately after the 2019 Spanish general elections that perceived issue saliency and partisanship matter for one's willingness to accept compromise in coalition negotiations. It is unclear, therefore, whether the findings of Fortunato's experiment with fictitious parties holds in a

politically salient context with high stakes.

To address these shortcomings and to test how citizens adjudicate between steadfast and compromising parties in the context of coalition negotiations, we focus on citizens' party evaluations of their so-called preferred party (i.e., 'in-party'), use highly salient issues during a real election campaign, and keep party strategy (i.e., compromise or steadfastness) and negotiation success (i.e., stalling or continuing talks) as distinct experimental conditions. Based on our discussion above, we argue that voters prefer to their 'in-party' to stick to its previous commitments, rather than conceding to a competing party.⁴ We therefore formulate the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1 (H1) *All else equal, in-partisans view their party more positively when a party remains steadfast in coalition talks, compared to accepting a compromise.*

At the same time, the literature on electoral winners and losers and on strategic rental voting for coalition purposes suggests that citizens prefer to see their party in government (Gschwend et al. 2016). Therefore, we expect that citizens prefer the negotiation process of government formation to be successful. Specifically, we expect that voters are more likely to place trust in their 'in-party' when the negotiations with a competing party to continue, as opposed to to a scenario in which the coalition negotiations falter. We posit the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2 (H2) *All else equal, in-partisans view their party more positively when coalition talks continue compared to the stalling of the coalition talks.*

Although we expect citizens to evaluate their 'in-party' more positively when it remains steadfast, we expect that a successful negotiation process mitigates this. We expect that citizens are more accepting of their party's willingness to compromise when the coalition negotiation move to the formation phase compared to when the talks break down, leading to the following hypothesis:

⁴The hypotheses and the empirical design discussed below have been preregistered. The preregistration can be found [here](#).

Hypothesis 3 (H3) *All else equal, in-partisans view their party that accepts a compromise more positively when coalition talks continue compared to stalling of the coalition talks.*

Individual-Level Mechanisms of Compromise Rejection

How does compromise acceptance differ among citizens? We argue that the tendency to reject or accept compromises is likely rooted in differences in personality and psychological dispositions. To fully understand why some people reject compromise, we examine the individual-level mechanisms behind compromise perceptions. In their theoretical exposition on the virtues of political compromise for representative democracy, Gutmann and Thompson (2014) argue that *the uncompromising mindset* is one of the biggest obstacles to political compromise. This “mindset”, according to Gutmann and Thompson, consists of two characteristics: *principled tenacity* and *mutual mistrust*. Principled tenacity refers to a mindset, or psychological trait, in which compromises are seen as unattainable because they violate deeply held core beliefs or principles (Gutmann and Thompson 2014, p. 70). While material interests are more amenable to compromise, compromise is more difficult on core moral principles. Indeed, Ryan (2017) finds that moralized attitudes are related to compromise rejection. Similarly, Wolak (2020, p. 43) finds that dogmatism is negatively related to compromise acceptance. In a similar vein, Arceneaux (2019) shows that absolutism is related to intolerance toward political disagreement and compromising politicians. Absolutism refers to a perspective in which a belief in universal moral values is combined with an idealistic worldview (Arceneaux 2019, p. 2). Importantly, however, Ryan (2014) shows that ‘moral politics’ is not limited to commonly assumed specific moral issues, such as same-sex marriage, abortion, or religious practices. Instead, citizens can hold moralized attitudes about a wide range of issues (Ryan 2014). We therefore expect that citizens who hold strongly principled views about the issue at hand, as well as citizens who adhere to an absolutist (or morally principled) worldview are more likely to reject compromise:

Hypothesis 4 (H4) *All else equal, the more principled an in-partisan is, the higher the evaluation of a steadfast party.*

The second characteristic of Gutmann and Thompson’s uncompromising mindset is mutual mistrust. Mutual mistrust refers to the belief that one’s opponents are “motivated mainly by a desire to defeat them and the principles for which they stand” (Gutmann and Thompson 2014, p. 85). Someone with high levels of mutual mistrust is cynical about the motives of their counterparts and, as such, is wary of brokering compromises. Political theorists arguing that political parties are normatively desirable as institutions of representative democracy highlight that regulated party conflict emphasizes that political victory is always partial and temporary (Muirhead 2006). When one mistrusts the other party’s motives, however, this ‘party spirit’ is in danger of being violated. We operationalize mutual mistrust as *social trust*. Social trust, or generalized trust, refers to a person’s trust in her fellow members of society. Social trust facilitates an open, cooperative social environment, encourages collective behaviour, and encourages consideration of the public interest (Mannemar Sønderskov 2009; Zmerli and Newton 2008). Social trust, moreover, lowers the barriers to interpersonal interaction and dependence. As such, it has often been said that social trust is key for citizens’ democratic commitment (Zmerli and Newton 2008). We argue that the same is true for citizens’ support for political compromise. We expect, therefore, that lower levels of social trust are related to a higher evaluation of an uncompromising party:

Hypothesis 5 (H5) *All else equal, the less social trust an in-partisan has, the higher the evaluation of a steadfast party.*

Data and Method

We test our hypotheses using a preregistered survey experiment fielded to a large sample of German adults immediately following the German *Bundestag* elections

of 2021 ($N = 7,562$). The necessary sample size was determined on the basis of a power analysis (see Figure OA.1 in Section A of the Online Appendix, OA – only available [online](#) due to page restrictions). Respondents were recruited through Respondi (now Bilendi). Respondi collects non-probability samples using non-random opt-in respondents. To ensure that our sample approximates a nationally representative sample, we use quota sampling with quotas for age, gender, and education.

Experimental Design and Protocol

The survey was conducted in German. Upon acceptance of an informed consent message, respondents were forwarded to the main questionnaire.⁵ Before receiving the treatment, respondents were asked to give their opinion about a number of issues, including the increase of the top tax rate and the introduction of speed limit on the German highway – two issues that were featured in the experimental treatment. In addition, respondents were asked to indicate how important they find these issues. Subsequently, and still pre-treatment, respondents were forced to select their preferred party (i.e., their ‘in-party’) from a selection of four parties. For design reasons, participants were forced to choose between the Social Democratic Party of Germany (*Sozialdemokratische Partei Deutschlands*, SPD), the Christian Democratic Union of Germany (*Christlich Demokratische Union Deutschlands*, CDU), the Greens (*Bündnis 90/Die Grünen*), and the conservative-liberal Free Democratic Party (*Freie Demokratische Partei*, FDP). Respondents, thus, had the choice between two left-wing and two right-wing parties. These parties were the fourth largest parties in the newly elected German *Bundestag* with the SPD being the largest parties (with 28.0 per cent of the seats), followed by the CDU (20.7 per cent), the Greens (16.0 per cent) and the FDP (12.5 per cent). These four parties were also the most plausible candidates for a coalition government.⁶ This design choice inevitably means that some respondents have selected an in-party that does

⁵The study has been approved by the Research Ethics Review Committee of one of the author’s home institutions.

⁶A CDU-led government was less likely given that the SPD won the plurality of the vote.

not align with their preferred party is not one of these four parties (i.e., voters from *die Linke* or AfD). Robustness tests in the appendix show that the findings are similar for respondents who report having voted for a party that is not one of these four parties (see OA I).

Experimental Treatment

As experimental stimulus, respondents were presented with a scenario in which their in-party is engaged in coalition negotiations. The experiment follows a 2×2 design. In the first condition of the survey experiment, the in-party remains steadfast on an issue or, alternatively, accepts a compromise (i.e., a policy concession). In the steadfast condition, the stimulus highlights that this position can hurt its chances of government participation, while in the compromise condition, the treatment highlights that this position is taken to improve its chances for political office. The second condition juxtaposes a scenario in which the coalition negotiations continue with a scenario in which the talks do not proceed to the final negotiation phase. Figure OA.8 in OA F shows that the manipulation was successful: those who saw a treatment with a party remaining steadfast statistically significantly reported that this was the case, compared to those who did not see it. The same holds for the second condition.

The treatment is introduced by a message that highlights that coalition talks were taking place at the time of the survey and that we would present respondents with a hypothetical party communication – in the form of an Instagram message – about hypothetical bilateral coalition talks with another party. In reality, three parties (the SPD, the Greens and the FDP) were engaging in coalition talks at the time of survey. For the purpose of our experimental design, our treatment focused on bilateral coalition talks. Although in reality the 2021 election result required three negotiating parties, bilateral coalition talks is very common in the German context. In fact, the SPD-Greens-FDP three-party coalition that governed from December 8, 2021 to November 7, 2024 was the first three-party coalition since Adenauer I (1949-1953) and Adenauer II (1953-1957). The subsequent Merz

government was again a two-party government (CDU/CSU - SPD).⁷ The fact that in reality tripartite negotiations took place could have led to people being pre-treated, subsequently affecting our results. However, in the [OA, Section J](#) we demonstrate that the results of our study are no different if we only select respondents that had knowledge of the negotiation talks. The results as presented in [Figures 2–5](#) remain unchanged.

Political parties can strike different kinds of compromises (White and Ypi [2011](#)). As Weinstock ([2013](#), p. 539) outlines, compromises can be *additive*, in which the compromise incorporates the initial positions of both parties. Compromises can also be *substitutive*, in which parties exchange each other’s positions (i.e, ‘tit-for-tat’). When it comes to spending on a certain policy issue, parties can also compromise to ‘meet in the middle’ to find common ground. The most arduous compromises, however, are *subtractive* compromises, in which a party is prepared to concede its previously held position. Our treatment focuses on this scenario of subtractive compromises in which the compromising party makes a policy concession on a single issue in order to improve its chances for political office. This is a strong type of compromise which, given the one-time exposure, is our preferred as experimental stimulus. As the examples of the German FDP in XXX and the Dutch Green-Left in 2017, coalition negotiations can falter because of a party’s unwillingness to budge on a specific issue. Our experimental treatment therefore has external validity. At the same time, the compromises that parties usually strike in coalition negotiations pertain to many more issues as well as the allocation of ministerial portfolios (see Gross et al. [2024](#)). The design of our experiment is therefore a somewhat stylised scenario, in which a single policy concession (or not) is accompanied by talks faltering (or continuing).

The treatment is presented to respondents in the form of an Instagram message to increase experimental realism and respondents’ engagement with the stimulus material. The Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2021 highlights that Instagram is a key source of political information for citizens (Newman et al. [2021](#)). The

⁷CDU/CSU is counted as a single, unified party here

Instagram posts closely follow the parties’ real branding identity (i.e., logos and colors). In an additional survey experiment presented in the Online Appendix C, we show that respondents spend more time with an Instagram-based image treatment than with the same treatment in simple text form. This difference is statistically significant at $\alpha < 0.05$. Hence, treatment exposure is higher when using visual cues in comparison to text-only cues.

In each treatment, we randomize whether the issue at hand in the coalition negotiations pertained to an economic issue or a cultural issue on which the negotiating parties took up opposing positions. This allows us to establish whether or not the treatment effects found are a function of idiosyncratic policy issues. We selected two relatively salient policy issues, because Plescia et al. (2022) find that issue salience matters for the evaluation of party compromises. The economic issue pertained to the question of whether or not the *top tax* rate for high incomes should be increased. The cultural issue addressed the question of whether or not a general *speed limit* on the German motorway should be introduced. To be sure, the speed limit, or *Tempolimit*, on the German motorway is a highly contested issue in German politics that touches upon cultural attitudes both with respect to environmental values as well as to questions of social lifestyle. Alberini et al. (2022) note that resistance to a general motorway speed limit is rooted in Germany’s ‘deep-seated cultural identification with cars’. Bamberg et al. (2020) have also found that car use is a distinct element of mobility culture.⁸

To ascertain that results were not driven by the negotiating ‘out-party’, we vary the party with which the in-party engages in coalition negotiations. For the SPD and the Greens, the negotiating partners were the CDU and the FDP – and vice versa. This ensured that each scenario contained a hypothetical negotiation between a left and a right of centre party. Moreover, according to the *Wahl-Kompass* data based on party statements there was political disagreement between the left-wing and the right-wing parties on these issues, but there was no disagreement on these

⁸One could also argue that the speed limit issue combines cultural and economic considerations given that the issue also pertains to (the lobbying of) the German car industry.

issues amongst neither the SPD and the Greens, nor the CDU and the FDP (see Thomeczek et al. 2021). We control for in-party and negotiating party in our models, and explore differential treatment effects in OA K and I, respectively. The full text of the treatments can be found in OA B. Figure 1 shows an example of a the stimulus material for secnarion in which the SPD takes an uncompromising stance (vs. the FDP) on the issue of the speed limit, while the talks are discontinued.

Figure 1: Example of Simulated Instagram Stimulus Vignette.



Dependent Variables and Manipulation Checks

In line with our preregistration, our key dependent variable is *trust* in the party. Immediately following the experimental treatment, we measure party trust with the question “Based on the Instagram message, how much do you trust [PARTY]?” using an 11-point scale ranging from strongly distrust (value of 0) to strongly trust (value of 10).

To explore the broader implications of political compromise on perceptions of representation, we also inquire about the perceived *credibility* of the party as well as the perceived *representational performance* of the party. We measured *credibility* with the question “To what extent do you think a party like [PARTY] acted

sincerely?” using an 11-point scale ranging from extremely insincere (value of 0) to extremely sincere (value of 10). Representational performance is measured by asking, “To what extent do you think a party like [PARTY] does a good job in representing its voters?” using a 11-point scale ranging from very poorly (value of 0) to very well (value of 10).

Following the dependent variables, we conduct two manipulation checks. The first manipulation check asked whether their party accepted a compromise or not. The second manipulation check asked whether the parties would continue the talks or not. In OA F, we show that the manipulations were successful. In addition, we test whether the results hold when excluding respondents who failed the manipulation check and we included a ‘reality check’ to see if knowledge about the real-world coalition negotiations affected responses to the experimental treatments. In OA K we show that this is not the case.

Measuring Individual-Level Mechanisms

Hypotheses 4 and 5 postulate that the individual-level mechanisms *principledness* and *social trust* affect individuals’ responses to compromise.

We measure *Principledness* in two different ways. First, following Arceneaux 2019, we measure principledness using the Ethical Positions Questionnaire using a 7-point Likert scale (*Strongly Disagree, Disagree, Somewhat Disagree, Neither Agree nor Disagree, Somewhat Agree, Agree, Strongly Agree*). We reduce the initial 20 statements to 12 based on an Item Response Theory (IRT) analysis, which showed that the level of information these 12 items brought to the latent construct was sufficient (see the online appendix, where statements 1–6 measure idealism and statements 7–12 measure relativism; absolutism is the combination of idealism with the rejection of relativism. Based on these items, we constructed an additive scale.

Secondly, we use Ryan 2017’s measure of Willingness to Accept Benefits, where participants imagine receiving money (€0, €1, €2, €3, €4) but donate the same amount of money to an organization that is against their preferred policy position on the policy issue for which they saw the fictitious Instagram party communication.

It is important to note that respondents were informed that no actual funds would be transferred.

Social trust is measured using three items adapted from the European Social Survey using an 11-point scale, where 0 is the most negative answer and 10 the most positive one. Respondents are asked whether they think most people can be trusted, most people try to take advantage of you, and most people are willing to help others. We create an additive scale based on these items.

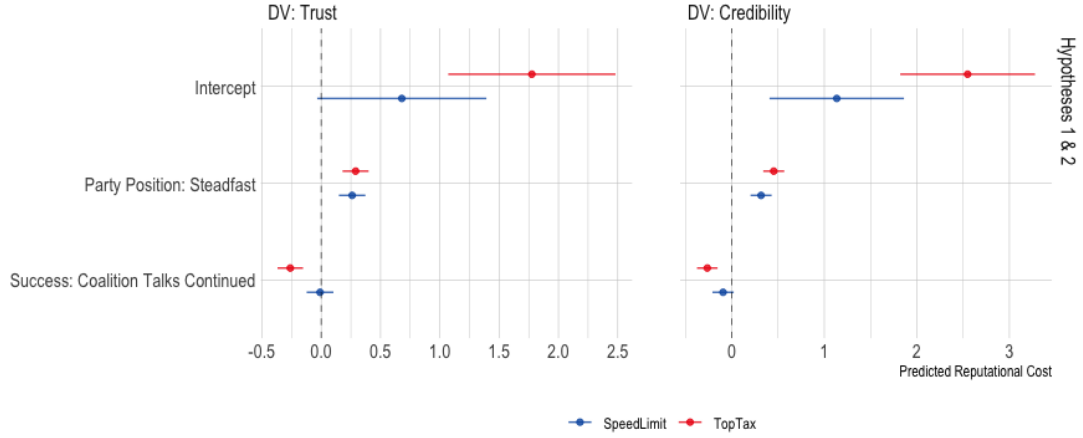
Control Variables, Balance Tests, and Attention Checks

Lastly, we measured a number of control variables before the treatment. The following *demographics* are measured: gender, age, education, geographical region, vote choice in the 2021 parliamentary elections, employment, and income. Balance checks were conducted to demonstrate whether certain categories are overrepresented in a certain experimental group. For the analysis, only variables that are unbalanced over the experimental conditions will be included. OA B gives an overview of the questions asked in the survey in the English translations. To ensure the quality of our data, we make sure only attentive respondents are included. To do so, we include two attention checks. Respondents failing the attention are excluded and replaced by another respondents who succeeds the attention check. The attention checks are discussed in more detail in OA B.

Findings: The Cost of Compromise

When and why does a party's acceptance or rejection of a compromise affect its political reputation? First, we will present the models testing Hypotheses 1, 2 and 3, along with relevant subgroup analyses. This is followed by a discussion of Hypotheses 4 and 5 testing the moderating individual-level effects of principledness and social trust. Finally, we probe the generalizability of the relationship between compromise attitudes and political trust across Europe with a preregistered cross-sectional analysis.

Figure 2: Predicted Reputational Cost.



Visualized results are OLS regression coefficients of variables of interest controlled for the unbalanced co-variables: Degree of urbanization, employment, region of residence and birth, left-right position of the respondent, attitude towards the speed limit and top tax policies, and issue importance of top tax.

For our tests of Hypotheses 1, 2 and 3, we present the results for our main preregistered dependent variable, *trust*, as well as for our exploratory dependent variable, perceived *credibility*, using OLS regression analyses. The results for our exploratory dependent variable perceived *representation* are shown in OA Section H.⁹ All models control for ‘in-party’ choice and ‘out-party’ negotiating partner. For H1 and H2, we show the effects for both policy issues (*top tax* and *speed limit*), but due the potential of lower power, we present the pooled results for the interaction hypotheses (H3-H5) – as preregistered. After a balance test (see Section E of our OA), we additionally include the following unbalanced covariates as additional control variables in all analyses: degree of urbanization, employment, region of residence and birth, left-right position of the respondent, attitude towards the speed limit and top tax policies, and issue importance of top tax as . In the paper, we only present the visualizations of the main variables of interest; in OA Section G the full regression tables with all coefficients are presented (see the [Online Compendium](#)).

⁹Section H of the OA is only available in the online compendium due to page restrictions: [Online Compendium](#).

H1: The Effect of Party Compromise

Figure 2 demonstrates the effect of being steadfast (as opposed to accepting a compromise) in the coalition talks (H1) in the upper row, as well as the effect of a success in the coalition talks (H2) in the second-upper row.

In line with Hypothesis 1, we find that people value remaining steadfast more positively than accepting a compromise. Specifically, being presented with a treatment in which their ‘in-party’ remains steadfast as opposed to accepting a compromise has a statistically significant positive effect on trust in the party. This finding holds both for the top tax and the speed limit issues (p-value = 0.000 for both issues). This finding suggests that parties incur reputational costs when accepting compromises to access political office. The effect size of 0.3 is, as expected, a small effect on the 11-point scale of trust, compared to the standard deviation of 2.41. However, as these situations in which a party trades off staying steadfast versus making a compromise happen regularly in real-life politics, the negative reputational effect of striking a compromise can likely accumulate. We find similar effects for the alternative dependent variables *credibility* and *representation*, with significant positive effects of remaining steadfast on both issues.

In OA Section I, we additionally demonstrate that these effects hold even when exploring heterogeneous treatment effects for different party choices or political moderators, i.e., issue congruence between respondent and party, ideological position of respondent, political interest, and political knowledge (Figures OA.14-OA.16).

We show that remaining steadfast is preferred over compromise for all parties, except for the SPD. For the SPD, there is no statistically significant effect of remaining steadfast on the *trust* outcome variable for both the top tax and the speed limit issue. SPD voters are likely more accepting of compromises because the SPD became the largest party in the election and was expected to form the government. In other words, SPD voters have likely already anticipated policy compromises and are therefore less negative.¹⁰ Since we force respondents to choose between four

¹⁰Split-sample analyses in OA I (Figure OA.17) show the results per reported party vote in the previous

‘in-parties’, it is possible that voters from parties not included respond differently to the treatment, such as the leftist *Die Linke* and the far right *AfD*. OA I (Figure OA.17) shows a split-sample analysis based on vote choice in the previous election. We see that the effects are substantively similar for all parties.

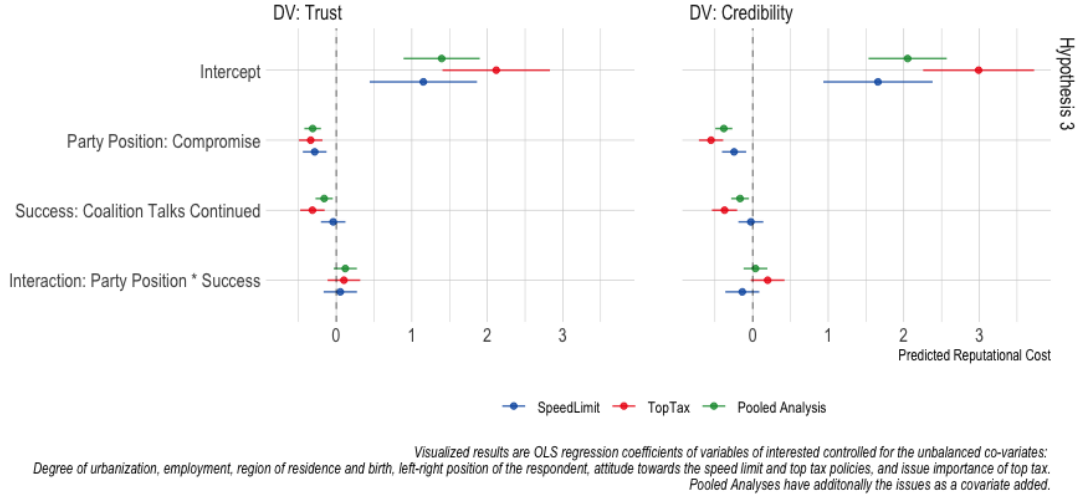
With respect to left-right self-placement, we see that the positive effect of steadfastness holds across the scale but fails to meet statistical significance for respondents on the far right. The treatment effect also holds across levels of political interest and political knowledge but is not statistically significant on the low ends of both variables. Additionally, we find that there is no difference between being congruent or incongruent with the party on the political issue; one still prefers the party to stay steadfast (see Figure OA.13), although there are some differences between the issues.

H2: The Effects of (Un)successful Talks

Hypothesis 2 stipulated that respondents would reward parties when the coalition talks with the negotiating ‘out-party’ continue (i.e., success), as opposed to when the negotiations stall (i.e., failure). However, this is not supported by our findings. For the top tax issue (in red in Figure 2), we find that continuing talks are actually valued less by respondents, as ‘continuing talks’ have a statistically significant negative effect on trust in the party (p-value = 0.000). The effect size of -0.26 is, as expected, a small effect on the 11-point scale of trust. A similar significant negative effect is also found for the dependent variables *credibility* and *representation*. With respect to the speed limit (in blue in Figure 2), we do not find a significant effect of continuing talks on trust or credibility (p-values of 0.887 and 0.831, respectively), but we do find a significant negative effect on perceptions of representation. These findings imply that an explicit office-seeking strategy – i.e., having success in coalition talks so that down the line the party can implement its policy preferences into policy – is not always rewarded by voters (see also Gross

elections. We show that remaining steadfast is preferred over compromise for all parties, except for the SPD.

Figure 3: Predicted Reputational Cost.



et al. 2024). Instead, it can come with negative reputational consequences. In OA J, we show that this negative effect is driven by respondents being lukewarm at the prospect of entering government with an ideologically dissimilar party altogether. In an interaction with ideological distance towards the potential coalition partner, we show in Figure OA.18 that the bigger the ideological distance between the partner and a respondent, the higher the reputational costs. This could be explained by the so-called optimism bias, which often drives discontent with compromise in practice. Voters can always imagine a better outcome and therefore get upset with party leaders for not holding their party to this sub-optimal situation.

H3: Does Success Soften the Costs of Compromise?

While we expected citizens to evaluate their in-party more positively when it remains steadfast, Hypothesis 3 expressed the expectation that there is an interaction effect between the party strategy (i.e., compromise vs. steadfast) and success in the negotiation process (i.e, talks continue vs. talks stall). Specifically, we expected that voters are more accepting of compromise when the party is successful in continuing the negotiations. However, Figure 3 shows that this does not hold

up empirically. We find no statistically significant interaction effect between party position and negotiation success for either *trust*, *credibility*, or *representation*. Calculating the marginal effects, we see that respondents prefer parties to stay steadfast regardless of the success of the negotiations. Even when we compare the evaluation of respondents who were exposed to stalling negotiations and their party being steadfast to respondents who were exposed to continuing negotiations and their party accepting a compromise (see OA K), we find that the former group (being steadfast and talks stall) evaluates the party more positively. This difference is statistically significant for credibility and representation, but not for trust. In other words, success in the negotiations does not attenuate the negative effect of compromises. This suggests that even when parties have the prospect of office in sight, partisans do not value it when the party compromises on the issue at stake. These findings suggest that citizens believe that commitment to previously voiced positions is more important than success in coalition talks.

H4 & H5: Moderators of Compromise Rejection

Turning to the individual-level moderators that drive compromise rejection, Hypothesis 4 posited that the more principled a respondent is, the more trust she places in a party that remains steadfast in coalition negotiations, as opposed to accepting a compromise. Figure 4 shows the heterogeneous treatment effects of our two measures of principledness on the steadfast/compromise treatment condition, with the first measure being the behavioral measure and the second measure being an attitudinal measure. We find that being principled has clear positive effects on appreciation for steadfast parties compared to compromising parties. This effect holds across the different dependent variables and across issues.¹¹ For the behavioral measure of principledness, we see in the upper panels of Figure 4 that going from being unprincipled (value of 0) to being very principled (value of 4), the appreciation for the party increases with 0.45 and 0.6 on an 11-point scale for trust

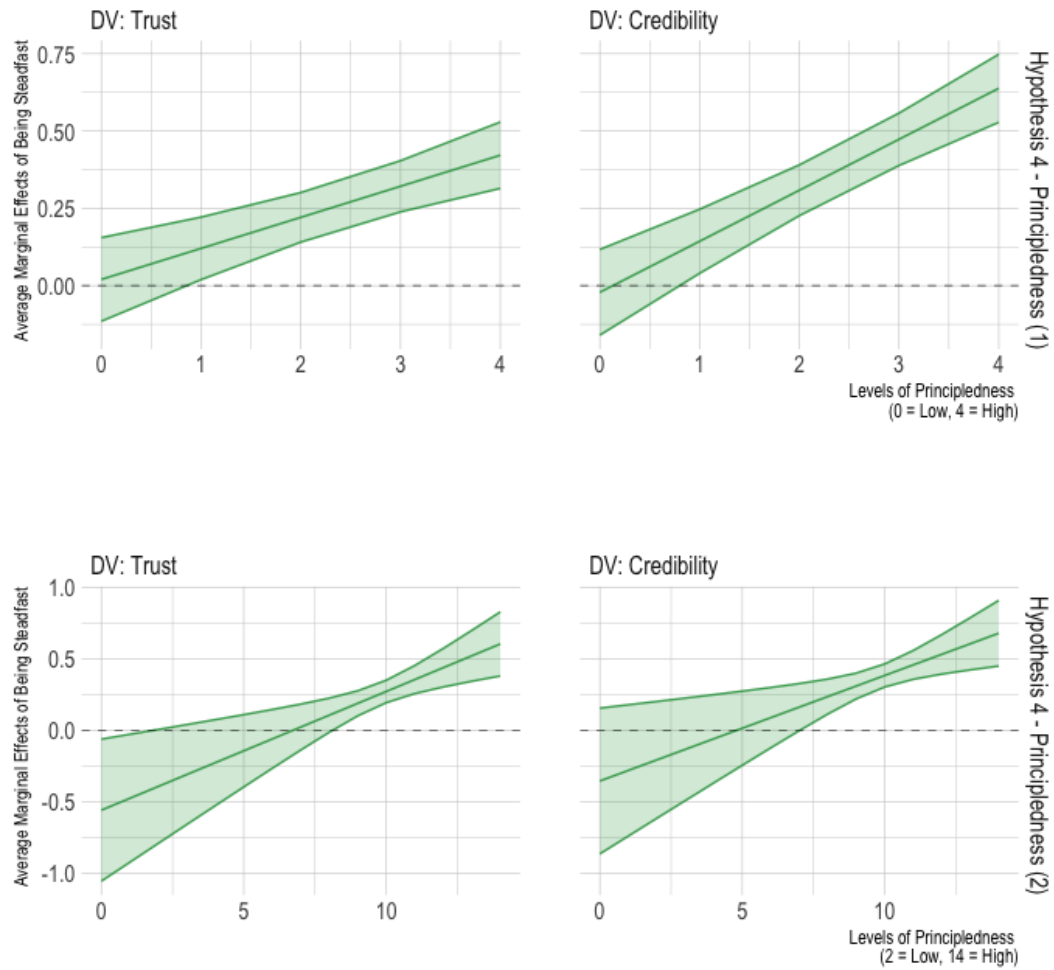
¹¹Figure OA.15 in Section H of the OA in the [Online Compendium](#) shows that the direct effect of principledness is close to 0, due to opposite effects on both sides of the scale.

and credibility, respectively. In Section H of the OA, we show that this effect is similar for representation (see [Online Compendium](#)). For the attitudinal measure, presented in the lower panels of Figure 4, we see that people who are not at all principled appreciate parties that strike a compromise, indicated by the negative effect of being steadfast on the dependent variables. In line with Hypothesis 4, we find that high levels of principledness, however, have the opposite effect. These respondents value parties that do not accept a compromise.

Hypothesis 5 formulated the expectation that citizens with higher levels of social trust are more accepting of compromises. Figure 5 shows the heterogeneous treatment effects of our social trust measure on the steadfast/compromise treatment condition.¹² In support of Hypothesis 5, we find that respondents with higher levels of social trust are more accepting of political compromise. The negative slope of the coefficient signifies that the higher one's level of social trust, the less pronounced the positive effect of steadfastness is on our main dependent variable. While we see the same effect on the alternative dependent variable *credibility*, we find a null effect for *representation performance*.

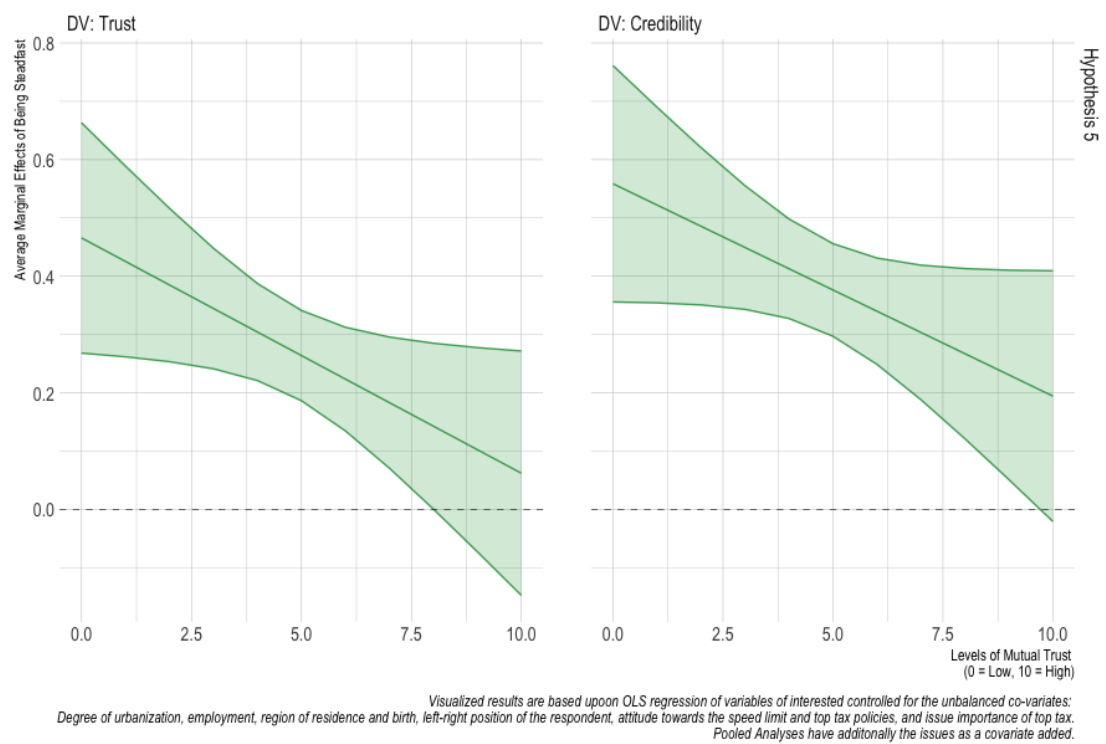
¹²Figure OA.15 in Section H of the OA shows that the direct effect of social trust is also positive and significant.

Figure 4: Heterogeneous Treatment Effect: Principledness.



Visualized results are based upon OLS regression of variables of interest controlled for the unbalanced co-variables: employment, region of residence and birth, left-right position of the respondent, attitude towards the speed limit and top tax policies, and issue importance of top tax. Pooled Analyses have additionally the issues as a covariate added.

Figure 5: Heterogeneous Treatment Effect: Social Trust.



Compromise Attitudes and Trust across Western Europe

Our study shows that parties' willingness to compromise breeds distrust in Germany. To what extent does the relationship between anti-compromise beliefs and political trust hold in cross-sectional fashion, and more importantly, does it hold across multiple countries? While a multi-country experimental study is beyond the scope of this paper, we conducted a preregistered pooled cross-sectional analysis of election study data in 9 West-European countries using OLS regression analysis. Specifically, to probe whether the relation between compromise rejection and political trust holds across countries, we examine the effect of holding anti-compromise attitudes on trust in parties and satisfaction with democracy.¹³ The operationalization of the variables of interest is discussed in OA M (see [see the Online Compendium](#)).¹⁴

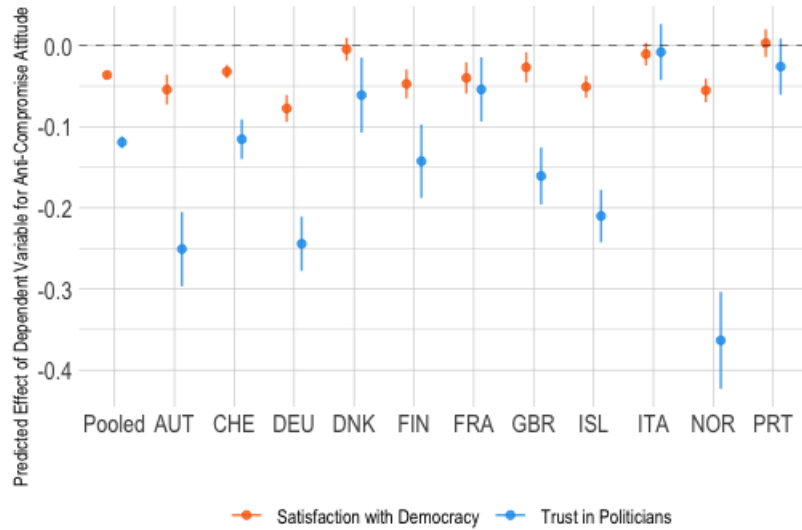
Figure 6 presents the results of the pooled cross-sectional analysis of election study data in the nine Western European countries (top row), as well as the effects per country in alphabetical order. The coefficient of *anti-compromise attitude* of -0.16 for the dependent variable *trust in politicians* in the pooled sample points to a negative and statistically significant effect, albeit rather small. As we hypothesized in our pre-analysis plan, the stronger one's anti-compromise beliefs, the lower one's trust in politicians. The negative effect on satisfaction with democracy is similar, yet smaller. Figure 6 shows that this effect holds for seven of the nine countries in our sample when it comes to **trust in politicians**, and in six out of nine when it comes to **satisfaction with democracy**. The relationship between an anti-compromise attitude and political trust does not hold in Italy and Portugal. Moreover, in Denmark, we find a significant negative effect on trust in politicians, but not on satisfaction with democracy. All in all, these findings suggest that anti-

¹³In keeping with the political trust literature, we control for respondents' age, gender, educational attainment, and household income. In addition, we control for relevant political attitude confounding variables known to influence political trust, including partisanship, political interest, and left-right placement. Lastly, to ascertain that we do not capture governmental performance, we control for evaluations of governmental performance. Since our interest lies in individual-level effects, we control for all country-level variation by including country fixed effects. We also estimate country-specific models.

¹⁴The preregistration was registered for 6 countries only (Austria, Germany, France, Italy, Netherlands, UK) given data availability at the time. We have complemented these six countries with more countries from CSES Module 5 upon their release. The preregistration can be found [here](#).

compromise attitudes and political trust correlate across most Western European national contexts. This provides suggestive evidence that our experimental findings may well apply more broadly beyond the German case.

Figure 6: Results Pooled Cross-Sectional & Country Specific Analysis.



Visualized results are OLS regression coefficients of variables of interested controlled for the co-variables: Political interest, left-right position of the respondent, satisfaction with the government's performance, party identity, gender, age, level of education, income. Pooled Analyses have additionally the separate countries as a covariate added.

Conclusion

Does parties' compromise acceptance during coalition negotiations affect their political reputations? The evidence from a survey experiment using 7,562 respondents in Germany, immediately after the 2021 *Bundestag* elections demonstrates that political compromises come at the cost of the parties' reputations. That is, when a party accepts a compromise (as opposed to remaining steadfast) on a key issue in coalition negotiations, this tends to be rejected its in-partisans, regardless of the success of these negotiations. In-partisans thus seem to value *policy representation* over *responsibility* in taking office, at least during coalition negotiations. This is line with the findings of Gross et al. (2024), who find that in-partisans tend to

prioritize policy congruence over office considerations. We have shown this for our preregistered dependent variable trust, and for our two exploratory outcomes that tap into broader dimensions of a party’s reputation, i.e. representation and credibility. Corroborating the claim by Gutmann and Thompson (2014), we further find that individuals’ ‘principled tenacity’ and ‘mutual trust’ affect compromise acceptance, as respondents with high levels of principledness and low social trust exhibit lower support for political compromise. An additional observational cross-sectional analysis on the basis of CSES data shows that the relationship between compromise acceptance and trust in politicians, as well as satisfaction with democracy, holds in most West European countries.

This study is not without its limitations. First of all, our study focused on one particular kind of political compromise during coalition negotiations: a *subtractive* compromise in which one of the parties removes their initial positions (Weinstock 2013, p. 539) to gain access to political office. As our study is one of the first to explore the causal effect of party compromise on trust, such a strong treatment was desirable. Yet, not all compromises need to be as arduous as subtractive compromises. Compromises can also be *additive*, when the positions of both parties are incorporated, or *substitutive*, when both parties agree to a position that was not part of the initial position of either party (Weinstock 2013, p. 539). Moreover, compromises in coalition negotiations can also involve non-policy related exchanges, such as ministerial offices (Gross et al. 2024). Future research should explore to what extent these kinds of compromises find public approval.

Second, we provide evidence of an implicit bias against compromise (vs. remaining steadfast) in government coalitions. It is possible, however, that political compromise is rejected in the short term for representational motives, while taking office is valued in the long term. However, our conclusion that compromises for the purpose of coalition participation affect distrust is buoyed by the extensive observational evidence offered by David Fortunato (2019; 2021), who shows that voters punish coalition parties with greater willingness to compromise. What is more, other experimental evidence also points to the conclusion that compromises

are not valued in practice (Harbridge et al. 2014; Fortunato 2021, Ch. 4). That said, the outcome treatment distinguishing between coalition talks continuing and talks breaking down may not have been sufficiently strong, as the “talks continuing” condition still reflected only partial progress, with the final outcome remaining uncertain.

Third, our study focused on compromises during coalition negotiations in Germany. Conducting the experiment during a real election enhances realism through genuine parties and issues, yet the scenarios remained hypothetical. As a result, the study captures the contextual engagement of an actual campaign but not the full behavioral consequences of real political events, thus only partially realizing its external validity potential.

Fourth, while presenting the treatment as an Instagram message effectively ensured exposure, it also limits generalizability, as Instagram is not a primary news source for most citizens (Newman et al. 2021) and conveys a more partisan communication style than traditional, non-partisan outlets.

Despite the outlined limitations, our study provides significant insights on three fronts. First, we illustrated the intricate dynamics of how citizens assess a political party’s openness to compromise during coalition negotiations, comparing it to the potential risks of unwavering steadfastness that could hinder government participation. While citizens seem to endorse compromise in low-stakes contexts as previous research has shown (Wolak 2020; Hjerimitslev 2025; GREEN-PEDERSEN and Hjerimitslev 2024), we show that citizens exhibit diminished trust in their party when it displays a willingness to compromise during coalition talks. This suggests that citizens’ commitment to political compromise is truly put to the test in a scenario where they have to trade-off policy losses vs. gaining political office. Second, we empirically elicited the individual-level moderators influencing the acceptance of compromises. Our findings reveal that high principled tenacity and low social trust amplify individuals’ negativity towards political compromises. Third, our generalizability probe across multiple European countries shows that the relationship between compromise rejection and political trust holds cross-nationally. In

conclusion, our study not only sheds light on these complex dynamics but also contributes valuable insights that deepen our understanding of the nuanced relationships between citizens, political parties, and the compromise imperative in democratic processes.

Our findings arguably paint a rather bleak picture of political representation in European democracies. Like many democracies worldwide, European democracies are increasingly marked by affective polarization (Bettarelli et al. 2022), increased electoral volatility (Dassonneville 2022), and the electoral decline of mainstream parties (Trubowitz and Burgoon 2022). As a result, coalition governments are constituted by increasingly diverse coalition parties (Nyrup and Bramwell 2020, p. 1372). This arguably has a profound effect on the need for cooperation and political compromise across parties. Cooperation between ideologically distinct political parties will require parties to broker more contentious compromises—yet such compromises do not appear to reduce affective polarization between opposing camps (Huddy and Yair 2021). Our findings suggest that this dynamic may, in turn, undermine trust in politicians and satisfaction with political representation.

In view of the centrality of political compromise in European democracies, our findings hint at the possibility that political distrust could be a *systemic* component of representation. What is more, if political compromise breeds distrust in mainstream parties and distrust propels the success of populist parties (Zaslove et al. 2024), the compromise-distrust nexus could well prove to be a vicious circle for modern democracies. After all, populist parties advocate an uncompromising, majoritarian vision of representation (Urbinati 2019), which is also shared by citizens with high levels of populist attitudes (Zaslove and Meijers 2023). More research is needed on whether political compromise in increasingly diverse governing coalitions does indeed drive political distrust and disenchantment with politics.

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